

Social Theory vs Conspiracy Theory: Is there a Difference?

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Research Question

The idea that powerful interests shape world events is not new. For example, the theory of the *military-industrial complex*, first warned about by President Eisenhower, identifies specific institutions such as defense contractors, the Pentagon, and Congress as mutually reinforcing forces behind perpetual war. In contrast, conspiracy theories like the *Great Replacement* imagine a shadowy group of unnamed "globalists" secretly orchestrating the replacement of the white race. Although both seek to explain perceived patterns in society, they differ profoundly in their structure and evidence. This paper asks: **Can conspiracy theories be systematically distinguished from social theories based on measurable linguistic and argumentative features?** It is proposed that conspiracy theories and social theories differ consistently in their use of evidence, emotional language, specificity of agents, and causal complexity. By analyzing online discussions of both conspiracy theories and social theories, we aim to identify systematic markers that separate conspiracy thinking from legitimate social explanation. This distinction matters for understanding how humans form beliefs, trust sources, and interpret the complex realities of modern society.

Course Connection

This project connects directly to several major concepts discussed in class, especially the theory of **epistemic counter-communities**. Epistemic counter-communities are groups that form around alternative systems of knowledge, often rejecting mainstream standards for evidence, credibility, and explanation. Instead, they establish their own norms for what counts as truth. Conspiracy theory spaces on Reddit function as prototypical epistemic counter-communities: they create shared narratives that resist traditional scientific or journalistic authority and instead rely on internal validation, anecdotal experiences, and emotional reinforcement. By analyzing conspiracy theory threads alongside social theory threads, this project aims to test whether these epistemic differences are not only ideological but also detectable in measurable linguistic and argumentative features, such as the use of moralizing language, citation frequency, or the specificity of agents. In doing so, the project addresses fundamental questions about how knowledge communities form and maintain their distinct epistemic boundaries.

Moreover, the project draws heavily on the idea of **explanatory values**. Different communities prioritize different traits when evaluating explanations. Formal academic and social theories typically value complexity, empirical adequacy, and fit with existing

well-established frameworks. In contrast, conspiracy theorists often prioritize different explanatory values, such as emotional resonance, simplicity, or narrative coherence over empirical support. For example, an explanation that "feels right" or that emotionally affirms in-group beliefs may be seen as stronger, even if it lacks empirical verification. By analyzing text features like causal complexity and the density of emotional language, the project operationalizes these differing explanatory values and connects them to real-world examples of divergent epistemic practices.

Finally, this research engages directly with the class concept of the **over-valuation of co-explanation**. People have a strong cognitive bias toward preferring explanations that unify multiple disparate phenomena under a single cause, even when such unification leads to loss of nuance or precision. Conspiracy theories exemplify this bias: many attempt to explain economic shifts, demographic changes, political events, and cultural trends with one hidden mechanism, such as the actions of a secret cabal or an orchestrated plan. By contrast, formal social theories often resist overly broad co-explanations, recognizing the multiplicity of causes behind complex phenomena. By scoring texts for causal complexity and examining the tendency to over-cohere explanations, this project tests whether conspiracy communities display a greater tendency to over-value co-explanation compared to communities engaged in structured social theorizing.

Thus, this project ties together several key course themes: the formation of epistemic counter-communities, the different explanatory values prioritized across knowledge systems, and the psychological appeal of co-explanation. In doing so, it explores deep questions about how humans construct, share, and defend their visions of reality.

Data Gathering

To test whether conspiracy theories differ systematically from social theories in linguistic and argumentative features, data was collected from two types of Reddit threads:

1. **Conspiracy Theory Corpus:** Threads from **r/conspiracy**, a subreddit where users discuss topics like the Great Replacement, secret elite control, vaccine misinformation, and other conspiracy narratives.
2. **Social Theory Corpus:** Threads from **r/AskSocialScience**, a heavily moderated subreddit focused on evidence-based discussion of social, political, and economic theories. Threads here often address complex topics like cultural comparisons, systemic inequality, globalization, and institutional power.

Example snippets from a social theory thread (r/AskSocialScience):

**r/AskSocialScience**

[+ Create Post](#) [Join](#)

Best ▾

 **u/Salt-Holiday-3967** · 1 hr. ago

Why are transracial people not accepted the way transgender people are?

Genuinely curious, don't intend to sound like an asshole. Someone who identifies as a different race they were born as would be terribly criticized and judged by society, besides called racist. Transgender people have millions of supporters and defenders. The argument is that "gender is a social construct" and it is undeniable that to an extent, gender roles, behaviors, and expectations are due to socialization. But race is also a social construct. "But we wouldn't be able to track racial inequality if anyone could identify as another race" same with gender. What would make this different?

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 **u/PSU-College-of-Ag** · Promoted

Learn to safely climb and maintain trees. Penn State Extension's Tree Climbing School is designed for arborists and others who work in and around trees. Gain skills you need and get hands-on experience in trees as you learn to climb and prune in this course for beginners. Takes place rain or shine.

AskSocialScience
Welcome to r/AskSocialScience! **The goal of AskSocialScience is to provide great answers to social science questions, based on solid theory, practice, and research** --
- Prior to posting, **please review the [AskSocialScience Rules] (http://www.reddit.com/r/AskSocialScience/wiki/rules)** or this summary: **1** All claims in top level comments **must be supported by citations** to relevant social science sources. No lay speculation. **2** Questions should be **novel and specific and
Created Jul 9, 2011
Public
174K Members **41** Online **Top 1%** Rank by size



SallyStranger · 5d ago

I'm surprised. I would not have thought a social sciences sub would be so gung ho for neoliberalism.

OP, I think you are generally correct.

"The BNPL data indicates that the story of global poverty over the past few decades is more complex, and more troubling, than existing narratives allow. Figure 1 shows that global extreme poverty increased quite substantially during the period of liberalisation and structural adjustment in the 1990s. Progress resumed in the 2000s. In 2011, around 17% of humanity could not afford basic essentials, down by less than 6 percentage points from 1980. The number of people in extreme poverty increased from 1.01 billion to 1.20 billion over this period."

OK, folks may say, but aren't things better now than they were, say, 200 or 300 years ago? Not necessarily. The extreme poverty we Westerners associate with "developing" nations is in fact usually an artifact of colonization or imperialism. That is, the forcible inclusion of nations/cultures in a globalized trading system.

"Historical data on real wages since the 15th century indicates that under normal conditions, across different societies and eras, people are generally able to meet their subsistence needs except during periods of severe social displacement, such as famines, wars, and institutionalised dispossession, particularly under European colonialism. What is more, BNPL data shows that many countries have managed to keep extreme poverty very close to zero, even with low levels of GDP per capita, by using strategies such as public provisioning and price controls for basic essentials.

In other words, extreme poverty can be prevented much more easily than most people assume. Indeed, it need not exist at all. The fact that it persists at such high levels today indicates that severe dislocation is institutionalised in the world economy – and that markets have failed to meet the basic needs of much of humanity."

<https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/inequalities/2024/04/30/new-research-on-global-poverty/>

For further reading, I suggest Hickel's "The Divide", and also "Late Victorian Holocausts" by Mike Davis.

[7](#) [Reply](#) [Award](#) [Share](#) ...



AlemSiel · 5d ago

Thank you! Reading the other replies would make you think there were no social scientist on this sub. Just propaganda. Or are north american academics this indoctrinated?

[3](#) [Reply](#) [Award](#) [Share](#) ...

[1 more reply](#)

[1 more reply](#)

Example snippets from a conspiracy theory thread (r/conspiracy):



r/conspiracy

+ Create Post

Jo

test

u/External-Noise-4832 · 7 hr. ago

They named it "PELOSI"!

S.58 - Preventing Elected Leaders from Owning Securities and Investments (PELOSI) Act

118th Congress (2023-2024)

BILL

Hide Overview X

Sponsor: Sen. Hawley, Josh (R-MO) (Introduced 01/24/2023)

Committees: Senate - Finance

Latest Action: Senate - 01/24/2023 Read twice and referred to the Committee on Finance. (All Actions)

Tracker: Introduced

1.6K

80

Share

conspiracy

This is a forum for free thinking and for discussing issues which have captured imagination. Please respect other views opinions, and keep an open mind. Our g is to create a fairer and more transparer world for a better future.

Created Jan 25, 2008

Public

2.2M

849

Members

Online

RULES

1

Bigoted slurs are not tolerated.

2

Address the argument; not the user, the mods, or the sub.

3

No blog spam/malicious web sites.

The Telegraph Your Say News Sport Business Money Opinion Ukraine Travel Health Lifestyle Culture Puzzles

Boeing 777s could cool the planet... if you don't mind acid rain

'Stratospheric aerosol injection' technique could put brakes on global warming, study finds, but with damaging knock-on effects



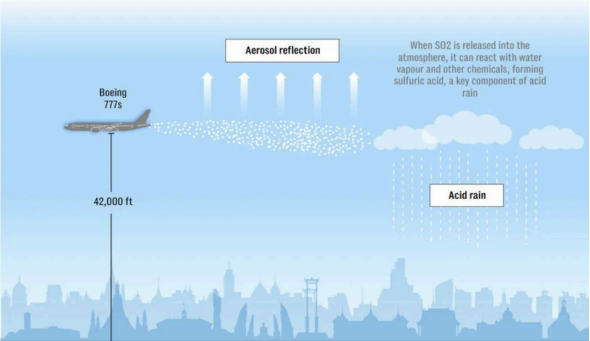
Sarah Knapton
Science Editor

Related Topics

Climate change, Weather, Boeing, University College London (UCL), Scientific research, Global warming

28 April 2025 4:13pm BST

How Boeing's 777s could cool the planet



The diagram illustrates a Boeing 777 flying at 42,000 feet, emitting a cloud of aerosols. Arrows labeled 'Aerosol reflection' point upwards from the aerosol cloud, indicating a cooling effect. To the right, a cloud is shown with arrows pointing down labeled 'Acid rain'. A text box explains: 'When SO2 is released into the atmosphere, it can react with water vapour and other chemicals, forming sulfuric acid, a key component of acid rain.'

431 148 Share

Join the conversation

Sort by: Best Search Comments

AutoModerator MOD · 1d ago · Stickied comment

Limp-Dimension-3897 · 1d ago

We're in the "it's happening but its a good thing" phase now.

113

Reply

Share

...

psjjj6379 · 1d ago

Next is, "okay yeah fine we've *been* doing it but it was only ever to protect you"

To ensure rigor and scalability, the **Reddit API** was used (via the Python Reddit API Wrapper, PRAW) to collect posts programmatically. Authenticated through Reddit's developer portal, a Python script was written to retrieve the **top 100 posts from each subreddit** from the **past year**. The script extracted each post's title and main body text and saved the combined dataset into a CSV file with labeled subreddit categories.

Snippet of CSV File:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1	subreddit	title	text						
2	conspiracy	Was pop star Sia trying to send a coded message about Beyonce and P Diddy?							
3	conspiracy	Thoughts?							
4	conspiracy	Shooter allegedly in Blackrock video, Video scrubbed.							
5	conspiracy	December 1st December							
6	conspiracy	does this all seem strangely surreal and scripted to anyone else?							
7	conspiracy	„This is an insult to the intelligence of the American people,“ - Luigi Mangione							
8	conspiracy	a Reddit classic							
9	conspiracy	What to Believe?							
10	conspiracy	Pure evil.							
11	conspiracy	So far this year....							
12	conspiracy	The 300+ year-old Vampire didn't kill himself.							
13	conspiracy	the Harris campaign wasn't wrong. YOU ARE.							
14	conspiracy	This qualifies as a major conspiracy theory							
15	conspiracy	Makes me wonder							
16	conspiracy	Did 15-20 million democrats just stay home? Or what, is the deal here?							
17	conspiracy	They want to pit us against each other while they live like kings							
18	conspiracy	Corruption							
19	conspiracy	20 Million Vo Where are these Democrats?							
20	conspiracy	How do you like							
21	conspiracy	How does so much MSM coverage anymore, is this the							
22	conspiracy	What the assassination attempt a farce? Is the CEO assassin a patsy?							
23	conspiracy	What Happened?							
24	conspiracy	Is this a cover up arrest to put the story to rest because they can't find the actual guy?							

To prepare this data for analysis, text analysis methods were applied. The approach includes:

- 1) **Citation detection**: Counting references to external sources (e.g., “source,” links, citations).
- 2) **Named Entity Recognition (NER)**: Measuring the specificity of agents referenced.
- 3) **Moral/emotional language**: Using dictionaries of emotional and moral words to compare tone.
- 4) **Causal complexity scoring**: Using ChatGPT prompts to rate how many distinct causes and how specific the agents are in each thread, on a 1–7 scale.

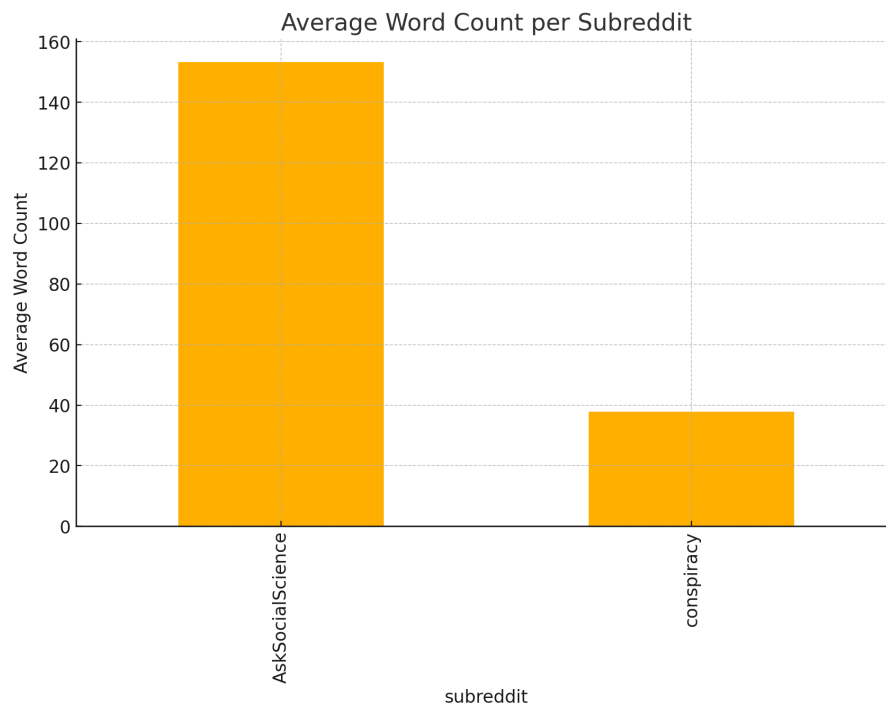
Raw and cleaned data are stored in labeled CSVs, backed up for transparency. This data allowed for quantitative evaluation of how two Reddit communities explain the world and whether linguistic markers reveal systematic epistemic differences. The data **totaled 19,103 words**.

Visualization

To communicate the key differences between conspiracy theory discourse and social theory discourse, a series of graphs was created that visualize quantitative findings from my dataset. These graphs include comparisons of word count, citation use, emotional/moral language, vague agent language, secrecy phrases, and complexity scoring metrics.

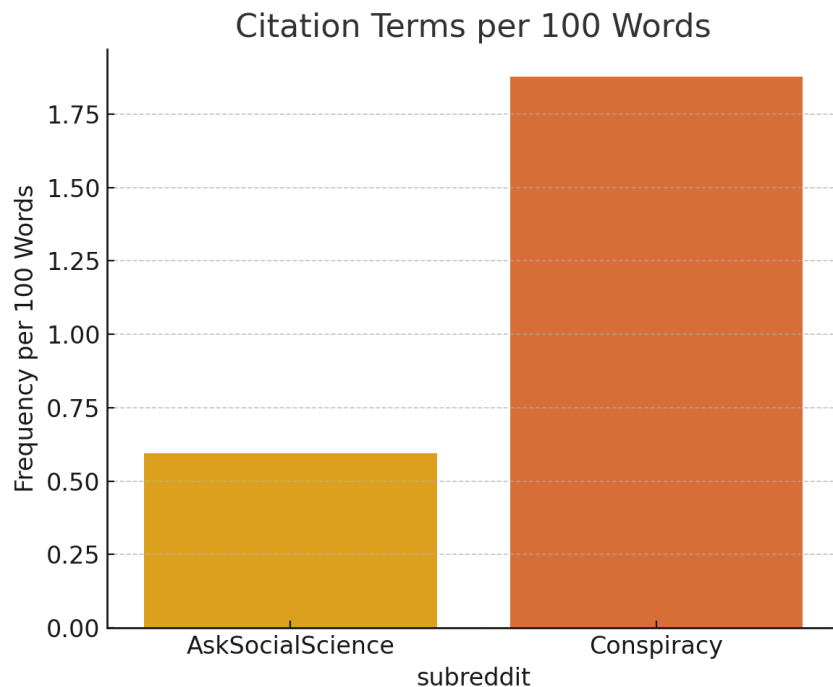
Graph 1: Average Word Count per Subreddit

This bar graph compares the average length of posts from each subreddit. Posts from r/AskSocialScience were significantly longer, averaging **153.22 words**, compared to only **37.81 words** for posts in r/conspiracy. This difference reflects the discursive norms of the two communities: social theory posts are often more detailed, potentially aiming to unpack complex arguments, while conspiracy posts tend to be short, slogan-like, and emotionally charged. The difference in post length provides a baseline for understanding further patterns.



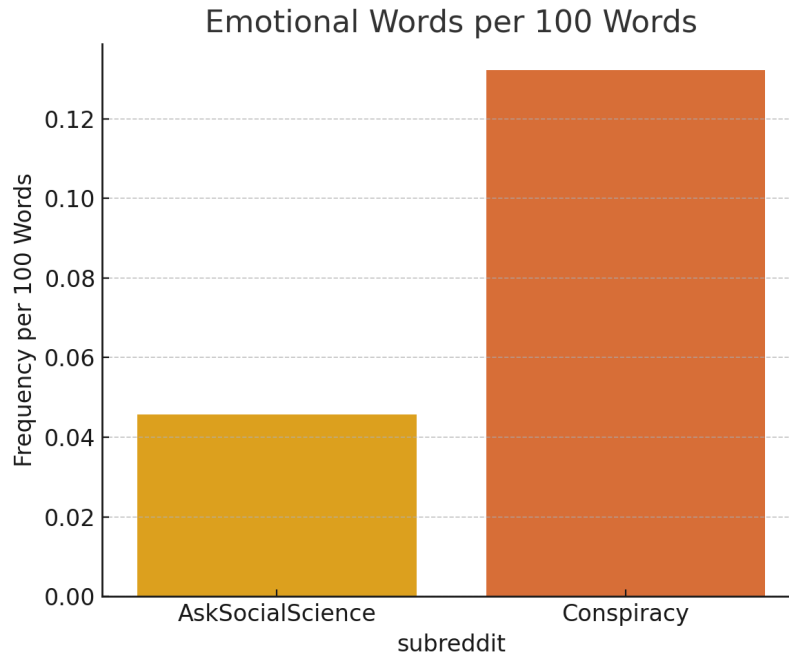
Graph 2: Citation Terms per 100 Words

This graph shows the frequency of citation-related terms such as “source,” “link,” or “https.” While r/AskSocialScience posts had a citation rate of **0.59 per 100 words**, conspiracy posts had a higher rate of **1.88 per 100 words**. Interestingly, despite using fewer total words, r/conspiracy users packed in more citation-like terms. This may indicate an appeal to legitimacy. It is important to note that we did not look at the quality of source being cited, which is obviously a large part of quality evidence for arguments and could skew results.



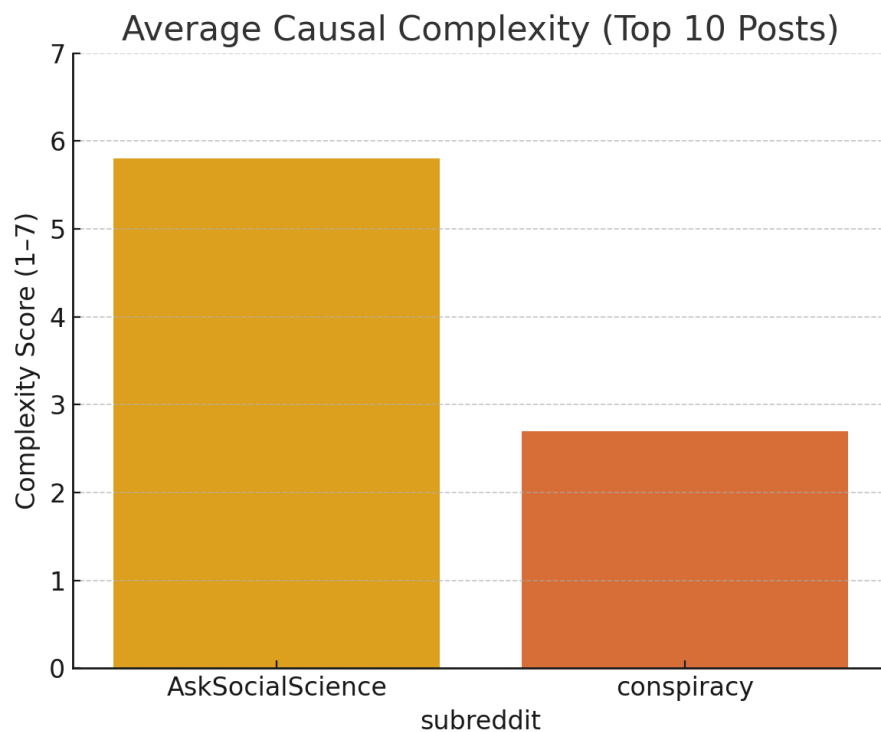
Graph 3: Emotional Words per 100 Words

This chart compares the emotional intensity of the posts using a basic dictionary of emotionally loaded terms such as “evil,” “truth,” “freedom,” or “wake.” Posts in r/conspiracy showed a higher density of emotional language, with **0.13 emotional terms per 100 words**, compared to **0.05 per 100 words** in r/AskSocialScience. This supports the claim that conspiracy theories prioritize emotional resonance and in-group reinforcement over empirical balance.



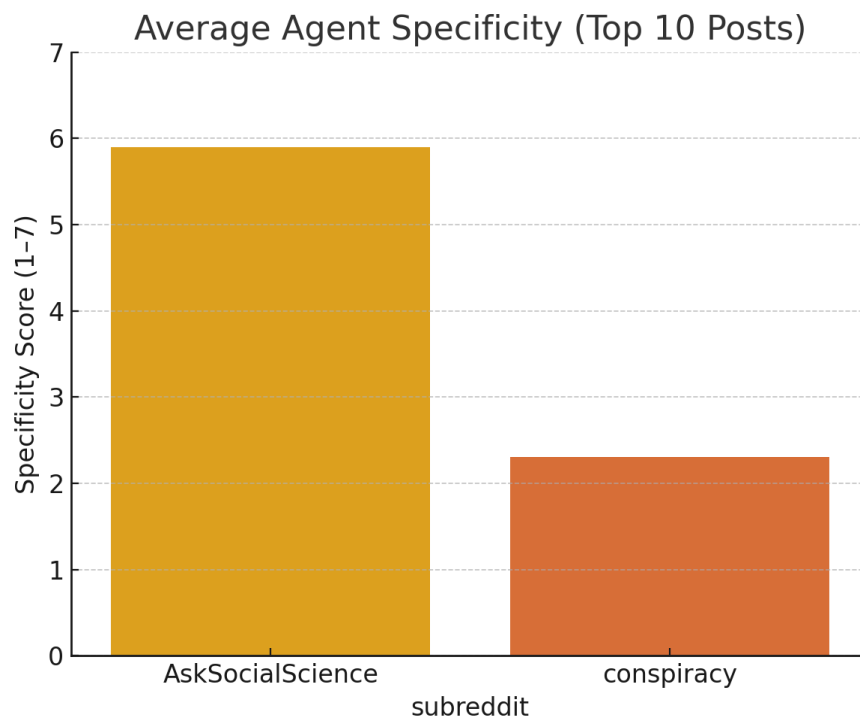
Graph 4: Causal Complexity (Top 10 Posts)

The ten longest posts were selected from each subreddit and had ChatGPT score them on **causal complexity** (i.e., how many distinct causes are discussed). Posts from r/AskSocialScience had an average complexity score of **5.8 out of 7**, compared to **2.7** for r/conspiracy. This suggests that social theory posts are more likely to view events as multifactorial and nuanced, whereas conspiracy posts often point to a single, overarching cause.



Graph 5: Agent Specificity (Top 10 Posts)

These same top posts were scored on **agent specificity**. This was measured by how clearly they name responsible actors (e.g., “the CIA” vs. “they”). r/AskSocialScience posts had a specificity score of **5.9**, while r/conspiracy scored only **2.3**. This indicates that conspiracy theorists often invoke more vague enemies (e.g., “the elite,” “the globalists”) without identifying institutions or mechanisms, further distinguishing their epistemic structure.



Analysis

To test whether the observed differences between subreddits were significant, Welch's t-tests were run on our key variables: word count, citation term density, emotional language density, causal complexity, and agent specificity.

Word Count

Posts in r/AskSocialScience were significantly longer, averaging 153.22 words compared to only 37.81 in r/conspiracy. This difference was highly statistically significant (**p = 0.0000377**), suggesting that users in social theory spaces tend to provide more elaboration, evidence, and argumentative depth. In contrast, conspiracy discourse tends toward brevity, often relying on implication, slogans, or emotionally charged shorthand. This result supports the hypothesis that epistemic counter-communities value a different kind of communication style, prioritizing resonance over depth.

Citation Density

Surprisingly, posts in r/conspiracy had more citation-related terms (1.88 per 100 words) than posts in r/AskSocialScience (0.59 per 100 words). However, this difference was **not statistically significant (p = 0.915)**. Crucially, this metric does **not account for the quality of citations**, which is arguably a more important epistemic indicator. A conspiracy theorist linking to an anonymous blog or unverifiable video is not equivalent to a social scientist citing a peer-reviewed study, even if both include the word "source." This underscores that **citation quantity alone is not sufficient** to evaluate epistemic robustness.

Emotional Language

Conspiracy posts included emotional or moral language at a higher rate (0.13 per 100 words) than social theory posts (0.05), but the difference was **not statistically significant (p = 0.420)**. While this supports the intuitive belief that conspiracist rhetoric leans heavily on affective appeal, the lack of significance suggests that emotional language is not unique to conspiratorial spaces. Indeed, social theories, particularly those dealing with race, inequality, climate change, or injustice, often employ emotionally charged framing as well. This may reflect an effort to **persuade the reader, highlight the stakes of an issue**, or align with **political and moral commitments**. This complicates the idea that emotion is a purely anti-rational feature of discourse and suggests that affective appeals play a role across many belief-seeking communities.

Causal Complexity

The top 10 longest posts in r/AskSocialScience had an average **causal complexity score of 5.8**, compared to just **2.7** in r/conspiracy. This difference was **significant** ($p = 3.79 \times 10^{-9}$). Social theory posts typically unpack multiple factors, engage with nuance, and acknowledge uncertainty. By contrast, conspiracy posts often attribute complex events to singular hidden causes. This supports class discussions about the overvaluation of co-explanation in conspiracist epistemology and reflects a fundamental divergence in how each community models the world.

Agent Specificity

Finally, the same top posts were scored for how specific their references to causal agents were. The difference was dramatic: **5.9** in r/AskSocialScience vs. **2.3** in r/conspiracy, with a significant result ($p = 2.26 \times 10^{-10}$). This finding reinforces the idea that conspiracy discourse relies on vague, unaccountable actors (“they,” “the elite,” “the globalists”), while social theory attempts to name and analyze institutional structures.

Discussions

The analysis reveals a mixed but revealing pattern. The most statistically significant differences of **post length**, **causal complexity**, and **agent specificity**, support the hypothesis that conspiracy theory and social theory communities construct knowledge in structurally distinct ways. Social theory posts were longer, offered more layered explanations, and referred to more specific agents. These patterns align with discursive norms that emphasize analytical depth and institutional reasoning. In contrast, conspiracy posts tended to be shorter, attributed events to single causes, and frequently invoked vague or unnamed actors.

By contrast, **citation density** and **emotional language** did not differ significantly between the two groups. This suggests that both types of communities make use of citations and emotional framing, though potentially for different reasons or in different ways. Importantly, this analysis did not assess the quality or credibility of citations, meaning that a post referencing a peer-reviewed article and one linking to a fringe blog would be counted the same. Similarly, while conspiracy discourse is often assumed to rely more heavily on emotional appeals, the presence of emotional language in social theory may reflect efforts to signal urgency, highlight injustice, or engage readers. These findings complicate the assumption that emotion or citation use clearly differentiates rational from irrational discourse.

Together, these results suggest that while some linguistic and argumentative features are shared across communities, the underlying structures of explanation and attribution

diverge in meaningful ways. Conspiracy theory spaces may not simply lack information, but instead reflect a different epistemic orientation. Future research could deepen this comparison by analyzing citation quality, mapping narrative structures, or tracing how users respond to disagreement or counter-evidence.

Conclusions

This investigation set out to determine whether conspiracy theories and social theories can be systematically distinguished based on measurable linguistic and argumentative features. The results offer partial support for the hypothesis, revealing that while some differences are subtle or context-dependent, others are consistent and statistically robust.

The most striking differences emerged in **causal complexity** and **agent specificity**. Posts in r/AskSocialScience offered more multifactorial explanations and named concrete institutions or actors (e.g., “Congress,” “the IMF”), while r/conspiracy posts frequently attributed causality to vague, abstract agents (e.g., “they,” “the elites”). These findings support the idea that conspiracy discourse relies on simplified narratives that appeal to over co-explanation, uniting multiple complex phenomena under a single causal frame, while social theory embraces nuance and systemic complexity.

Post length also significantly differed, with r/AskSocialScience posts averaging over four times as many words as r/conspiracy posts. This reinforces the notion that social theory communities value elaboration and argumentation, while conspiracy communities often prioritize emotional impact, catchphrases, or slogans over analytic depth. In this sense, the brevity of conspiracy discourse may reflect a communicative style geared toward persuasion and group cohesion, not detailed epistemic inquiry.

Two hypothesized differences, **citation frequency** and **emotional language**, did not yield statistically significant results. This challenges the assumption that conspiratorial communities reject citation practices or rely uniquely on emotional appeals. Instead, both subreddits appear to engage in citation and emotion use, albeit potentially for different rhetorical ends. This outcome suggests that the **presence** of citations or emotion is not itself diagnostic of epistemic quality. Rather, we must examine how they function within discourse (e.g., the credibility of sources, the framing of moral claims). These results contradict common caricatures of conspiracists as merely “irrational” or “anti-evidence.”

The study supports the view that conspiracy theorists are not simply uninformed but are operating within a distinct **epistemic culture**, one that prioritizes coherence, emotional resonance, and suspicion over empirical falsifiability. This aligns with theories of **epistemic counter-communities**: groups that reject mainstream knowledge norms and

substitute their own criteria for what counts as truth. The data here show that these epistemic commitments manifest not only ideologically but also linguistically, in the structure of their posts, the specificity of their claims, and the complexity of their causal explanations.

This project offers broader insights into the challenges of dialogue across differing epistemic communities. If conspiracy and social theory communities are constructing knowledge differently at a structural level, then disagreement is not just about *facts*, but about what counts as *a good explanation*. This has profound implications for communication, political polarization, and public trust. Efforts to bridge these divides may require more than debunking false claims; they may require engaging with the values, identities, and differing explanatory preferences.